REFERRALS

A thoughtful referral conversation

A checklist for referring a client to a colleague: sharing the need, checking the fit and closing the loop.

AUDIENCE	FORMAT	VERSION	TIME
Psychologists · Psychiatrists	Checklist	1.0 · Nov 2026	10 minutes

WHAT IT IS	A short checklist for the conversation with a colleague before and after a referral.
USE IT WHEN	Each time you refer a client out, or a colleague asks whether you can see someone.
CUSTOMIZE FIRST	What your client has consented to share, and your state's rules on releases of information. PA-07 covers termination and transfer of care.

1. Start with the essentials

- [ ] Share the clinical area, the client's state, setting (virtual or in person), age group and any practical needs such as insurance or language.
- [ ] Use an anonymous label. No names or identifying details until the client consents and a colleague has agreed.
- [ ] Say how soon the client needs to be seen.

2. Check the fit

- [ ] Confirm the colleague is licensed where the client is located.
- [ ] Ask about current availability and realistic wait times.
- [ ] Ask whether the work is within their competence and how they usually approach it.
- [ ] Check practical fit: fees, insurance, location, hours, language.

3. Make the handover

- [ ] Obtain the client's written authorization before sharing identifying or clinical information.
- [ ] Give the client the colleague's contact details and what to expect at first contact.
- [ ] Share records through your own secure process, on a minimum-necessary basis.

4. Close the loop

- [ ] Confirm with the client that contact was made.
- [ ] Thank your colleague; ask for a brief acknowledgement once care has started, if the client agrees.
- [ ] Record the referral and the outcome in the client record.

BEFORE YOU USE IT

Share identifying information only with the client's written authorization, and only what is necessary. A colleague must be licensed in the state where the client is located. Referral fees and fee-splitting arrangements are restricted by ethics codes and many state laws; PsyAlliance never takes or pays them. This checklist is educational and is not legal or clinical advice.

NOTES